

# Party Systems, Governance, and Citizen Disaffection in Latin America

As we close our exploration of Latin American politics, we turn to two democracies that illuminate the region's defining paradox. Both Brazil and Chile entered 2022 with robust institutional frameworks and recent histories of democratic stability. Yet both confronted profound crises of citizen confidence.

The tension we examine today centers not on democracy's survival, but on its representation crisis: the weakening of political parties as mediators between citizens and the state, and the widening mismatch between governance capacity and social expectations.

These cases remind us that **elections can remain competitive even as governability and legitimacy erode.**



# Brazil 2022: Party Disintegration and the Politics of Memory

## The Erosion of Party Anchors

Brazil's 2022 election was fundamentally a contest between two presidents — Lula and Bolsonaro — rather than between two party programs. The traditional partisan structure that once organized Brazilian politics has collapsed into stark personalization.

### The PSDB-PT Era

Traditional center-right and left anchors that structured Brazilian democracy for decades have lost their organizing capacity

### Bolsonaro's Trajectory

Eleven parties in three decades, constant congressional conflict, and failed party creation epitomized partisan disarticulation

### New Mobilization

Social networks, evangelical churches, and direct affective appeals bypassed traditional representation machinery

## Lula's PT: A Party of Memory

The PT stands as one of few surviving programmatic parties in Latin America. Its internal discipline and brand identity — *petismo* — gave Lula an enduring electoral base even after corruption scandals and imprisonment.

Yet this success reveals critical limits: the PT has become **more capable of reactivating nostalgia than articulating new projects**.

## Governance and Fragmentation

Bolsonaro's legislative relationships were purely transactional, relying on the *Centrão* — ideologically fluid parties trading budgetary amendments for loyalty.

This short-term coalition logic blurred accountability and deepened public cynicism about corruption and opportunism, transforming policy debates into identity battles.

# When Identity Replaces Trust

- ❏ When programmatic parties weaken, affective identity fills the gap. Citizens continue to participate, but through emotional polarization rather than institutional confidence.

## Lula's "Party of Memory"

Mobilizes nostalgia for past achievements and workers' movement identity, offering continuity with the PT's founding ideals but limited vision for future transformation

## Bolsonaro's "Movement of Resentment"

Channels anti-establishment anger and cultural grievances, creating cohesion through opposition rather than programmatic proposals

## The Mirror Effect

Both mobilize passion and cultivate fierce loyalty. Neither rebuilds institutional trust or creates sustainable governance frameworks

This dynamic explains a recurring regional pattern: citizen support for democracy remains high in the abstract, yet support for democratic institutions remains profoundly fragile. Lula's narrow 2022 victory restored procedural legitimacy but did so without rebuilding the institutional bridges that make democratic governance sustainable.



# Chile 2022: The Constitutional Moment and the Post-Partisan Dream

Chile entered 2022 with the promise of generational renewal. The Constitutional Convention and the Boric government emerged from a common impulse: to replace elite party politics with participatory, moralized politics.

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## Institutional Innovation

Gender parity, reserved indigenous seats, open lists for independents — all designed to bypass traditional parties

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## Atomization

Independent delegates pursued symbolic causes — animal rights, gastronomy, spirituality — disconnected from material priorities

02

## The Hidden Cost

Dismantling parties' mediating role in aggregating interests, filtering demands, and disciplining negotiation

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## Voter Rejection

62% rejected the draft constitution, signaling rejection not just of text but of politics without organization

## Boric's Coalition and Governance Limits

President Gabriel Boric faced a parallel dilemma. His coalition, *Frente Amplio*, emerged from student movements rather than party hierarchies. Its legitimacy derived from moral authority and generational freshness, not institutional experience.

**The challenge:** outsider structures proved ill-suited for governing a fragmented Congress and managing crises like inflation and the Mapuche conflict.



# From Euphoria to Disillusionment



📄 **Political innovation without organizational backbone breeds volatility.** Parties once derided as obsolete re-emerged as necessary for stability. Yet in the process, citizens grew profoundly disillusioned.

Early missteps by ministers, internal rivalries, and inconsistent messaging revealed that **moral legitimacy cannot replace bureaucratic competence**. When the constitutional process collapsed, Boric had to turn to the older, more experienced *Socialismo Democrático* parties — the very establishment his generation sought to transcend.

# From Representation Crisis to Governance Crisis

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| <p>Citizen Disaffection</p> <p>The gap between expectations and performance widens when party systems fail to translate social diversity into coherent policy. Citizens disengage not from politics itself, but from its institutional forms.</p> | <p>Delegative Democracy</p> <p>Presidents claim direct legitimacy from the people, bypassing parties and legislatures. This logic appears in both Bolsonaro's populism and Boric's moral voluntarism, creating governance without mediation.</p> | <p>Affective Polarization</p> <p>Emotional attachment replaces institutional confidence. Citizens define themselves "against" others rather than "within" a collective project, transforming democracy into a zero-sum arena.</p> |

These dynamics redefine the nature of citizen support: **participation remains high, but patience and trust are thin.** Without credible parties and effective governance, citizens oscillate between populist enthusiasm and technocratic resignation.

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|  <p>High Participation</p> <p>Citizens continue voting, protesting, debating</p>       |  <p>Weak Mediation</p> <p>Parties fail to connect demands to governance</p>   |
|  <p>Eroded Trust</p> <p>Institutions lose legitimacy despite democratic procedures</p> |  <p>Cyclical Crisis</p> <p>Oscillation between enthusiasm and resignation</p> |

# Conclusion: After the Cycle of Disaffection

If we zoom out, Latin America's recent experience is not of democratic collapse but of **democratic fatigue**. Citizens are still voting, protesting, debating — but increasingly against something rather than for something.

## Where Governance Works

Uruguay and Costa Rica: party systems still mediate expectations, creating stability through institutional trust

## Where Governance Underperforms

Brazil and Chile: citizens swing between the charisma of leaders and the moral urgency of movements

❏ Democracy's endurance no longer guarantees its vitality. Competitive elections and civil liberties persist, but the connective tissue between citizens and governance continues to fray.



## Institutional Reconstruction

Parties must rebuild capacity to aggregate interests and filter demands



## Mediation Restoration

Reconnecting citizen expectations to governance realities through transparent processes



## Trust Rebuilding

Demonstrating that democratic institutions can deliver responsive, accountable governance

For the region — and for us as analysts — the path forward requires recognizing that **democratic infrastructure matters as much as democratic ideals**. Only by rebuilding the mediating institutions that connect everyday struggles to policy outcomes can Latin American democracies move from survival to genuine vitality.